

with their existing landscape of proprietary systems and are quite surprised when it does so well," he adds.

There are challenges too

Although Gupta believes that the open source way of developing software is now ubiquitous, there are a few challenges involved in the process. He says, "One prominent challenge is the confusion regarding whether open source is free or commercial in nature and why one should opt for the commercial open source. The truth is that there is great respect today among customers for what open source can achieve. Hence, they are looking for advisers and organisations that not only have a great open source technology but can support them in the long run. Particularly in the case of Liferay, there is a great amount of awareness and it is spreading fast. Our service partners are also playing a crucial role by spreading awareness about open source technologies and helping the customers understand the best way to use our technology."

One of the biggest reasons for the growth of the open source business model is the cost advantage it provides compared to proprietary technology. The other factors helping open source are its ease of integration with other products, standardisation and the quality of the open source products. However, there are problems related to it as well, which any business dealing in open source may encounter. Gupta clarifies, "Customers often assume open source and free software are the same. That's where we find it hard to make them understand the value of the services offered by commercial open source vendors. However, in the last two to three years, the number of such customers is dropping and the number of customers that are willing to adopt open source and purchase commercial open source technology is steadily rising. The partner ecosystem that helps build solutions around open source is also growing by the day. Hence, while there were some difficulties faced when convincing customers a few years ago about adopting open source, now this task is much easier than ever before. Another apprehension that we commonly encounter is related to the security aspect of open source projects. Since the code is available to everyone, people think that open source software is more prone to security attacks. But with increasing awareness, things seem to be changing."

Just as there are always two sides of each story, there are both positive and negative aspects of any open source business model. But making money out of open source technology is getting increasingly easy now, asserts Gupta. He says, "I think, it is easier to make money from open source than from proprietary software, but I am not sure if you can make a lot of money. The open source consumers are highly cost aware and their budgets are usually low. Therefore, you will have to justify each penny you are going to charge them."

The Liferay products

Liferay is distributed in two different editions:

Liferay Portal Community Edition: This is a version that has the latest features and support offered through the active community.

Liferay Portal Enterprise Edition: This is a commercial offering with services that include updates and full support. This release goes through additional quality assurance cycles and is usually available around 1 or 2 months after the Community Edition comes out; it is under a non-free licence.

Liferay also provides a collaboration suite based on the Liferay platform:

Liferay Social Office: This is a social collaboration suite for enterprises.

Additional Liferay products and projects include:

Liferay Sync: This enables Liferay Portal users to publish and access documents and files from multiple environments, including Windows and Mac OS desktops, and iOS and Android-based mobile platforms.

AlloyUI: This is a UI framework for building Web applications.

Liferay Faces: This is an umbrella project that provides support for the JavaServer Faces (JSF) standard within Liferay Portal.

Liferay IDE: This offers a set of Eclipse plug-ins for development with the Liferay Portal platform.

Staying connected with the community

Even if open source technology is a successful business model, a strong link to the community is important. Liferay has a buzzing community that vouches for it. Gupta says, "The community is like a democratic voice of the open source product, and it is easy to see its strengths and weaknesses and make better decisions for the business by listening to what the community is saying. Therefore, it is extremely important to have a good community around your open source technology. We at Liferay are very thankful to our community for its support. Many of our new features, enhancements and bug fixes have been contributed by our community and their contributions have always helped us in delivering the best quality releases of our product. I believe that no open source project can grow to a significant size without an active community. Apart from code contribution, the community has also given us many of our colleagues at Liferay. I, too, was part of the community before joining Liferay."

Tip for an open source business

To be successful in an open source business, an organisation should offer a very good product that fulfills a unique space and meets diverse needs. This allows the technology to be used in different ways and, thereby, invites increased adoption. Increased adoption itself means good business, as there will always be enough buyers willing to pay for open source support and partners willing to invest in the technology. 